

Meanings of "Should"

4th year, 2nd semester

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- **Duty/Obligation (Weak):**

- "He should be at home." (Implies a **weak obligation** or **normative expectation** – less forceful than **must**.)
- **Suggestion:** Emphasize it's a weaker form of obligation.

- **Expectation/Probability:**

- "He should be at home." (I expect him to be at home, based on information; it's **highly probable**.)
- "That should do." (I expect that to be **sufficient**.)

- **Conditional (Inverted):**

- "Should you come, bring your friend." (A more **formal or hypothetical conditional** statement, equivalent to "If you happen to come..." or "If you were to come...")

- **Suggestion/Advice:**

- "You should meditate regularly." (A recommendation for what is **advisable** or **beneficial**.)

- **Regret/Criticism of Past Action (with Perfect Infinitive):**

- "You **should have told** me." (You didn't tell me, and it was the right thing to do, or it would have been better if you had.)
- **Meaning:** Expresses that a different, better action **could/ought to** have been taken in the past.

- **Surprise/Unlikelihood (Formal/Subjunctive-like):**

- "It's strange that he **should say** that." (Expresses mild surprise or incredulity about a fact or possibility.)
- "I insisted that they **should wait**." (Often used as an alternative to the base form subjunctive after verbs like **insist, demand, recommend**, especially in British English, adding a nuance of mild obligation or expectation.)
- **Meaning:** Indicates something unexpected, surprising, or a slightly softened sense of necessity/recommendation in a formal context.

- **Questioning Justification/Hypothetical Consequence:**

- "Why **should I** care?" (Implies there's no reason to care, or questions the logic/justification of an action.)
- "How **should I** know?" (Implies an inability to know, often rhetorically.)
- **Meaning:** Used in rhetorical questions to express defiance, lack of justification, or inability.